Redefining Sovereignty

Empowered with Terry Tripp — Transcript

Introduction: Why This Topic Matters

If sovereign means the controlling of everything, then a sovereign would never give an instruction that calls for a decision. Not everything that happens is God's will. If everything that happens were God's will, then it would be God's will for me to tell you that not everything that happens is His will. Get ready: we're going to redefine sovereignty. This is Empowered with Terry Tripp.

Why is this topic so important? There are two reasons. First, you will never experience God greater than your perception of God. Of course, God is God regardless of your concept of Him, but you'll never experience Him greater than your concept.

This is just one illustration, but it is God's will that everyone be healed. Yet some people have heard their entire lives that God can heal if He chooses to, so they just wait on God. "If it's meant to be, then God will do it." So they never pursue healing; they just sit around and wait for it. They don't understand that there are laws that govern healing. God has already healed in Christ Jesus. It's not that He's going to do it; He has already done it. But we must receive it. We must apply it and appropriate it. Sometimes we must release it, and sometimes we have to get angry enough to stop putting up with it. If you can live with sickness, you will live with sickness. You've got to get mad. You've got to put your foot down and say, "No more."

God's will is that you be healed. Whether you resist it or embrace it doesn't change who God is, but it hinders God's perfect will from being done if you're not embracing His will. So you will never experience God greater than your concept of Him, and there are many concepts in our culture today, even in church culture. That is why this topic of redefining sovereignty is, in my opinion, the most important thing we can hear as believers.

The second reason this is so important is that we have a major part to play in this earth. Every day we get up, we are sowing seeds that will ultimately produce a harvest. Our thoughts are seeds. Our words are seeds. Our actions are seeds that cause and create environments for us, for those around us, and for generations to come. We can't blame God for things we allow.

Chapter 2: Destructing False Doctrines

Before we construct an accurate definition of sovereign, we must destruct the definition that has been built for centuries through religion. There is a concept that has been framed for centuries through religion, denominations, and simply a lack of being in the Word. This concept is expressed in many ways, such as the idea that every horrible thing and every sinful thing is ultimately governed by God. And that's a problem.

Here are some of the ways this idea is commonly voiced: "Sometimes I use the devil to deliver my mail." "Could God be using Satan to demolish what has to be torn down?" "In His sovereign will He has chosen and elected those He would save." "The Bible is clear that God is in control over

every square inch of the world." "Our pain is not an accident." "God is sovereign over the storms of this life, and He has good in store for His people in their suffering." "God is in control over everything."

The sovereignty concept is one of the most crippling doctrines that has ever been believed. Don't misunderstand me: I believe God is sovereign in the way the dictionary explains sovereign. But the way the dictionary explains that word, as opposed to the way religion has explained it, is like night and day. The dictionary defines sovereign as a supreme ruler possessing ultimate power above all. I have no problem using that definition to say God is sovereign. Yet most sermons and statements that refer to God as sovereign are far from that definition.

The explanation given by mainstream religious people is usually in the context of God controlling everything. A pastor once told me that we should never question why things happen the way they happen; we should simply believe that God had a purpose in it, because after all, He is all-powerful and sovereign.

In our quest to redefine sovereignty, I want to say this right up front: God didn't allow slavery or the Nazis to kill Jews. God doesn't allow abortions. He didn't make your baby with incomplete parts. He is not the cause of storms, tornadoes, tsunamis, and all of the things called "acts of God" in our insurance policies. That is not God. I know some people will say, "But Terry, God is in control." That's a lie. That's fake news, and that's what religion has reported: that God is in control.

God is not the one who allowed a disturbed individual to go into a church and open fire on people who were worshiping. God is not the one who allowed the boy in Florida to open fire on students. God is not the one who sets a date for everyone's death.

Chapter 3: Jesus as the True Standard

So where do these kinds of doctrines and concepts come from? There are several places. Many people construct their picture of God from various philosophical premises or from their own life experience. While philosophical thinking can be helpful and life experiences cannot be ignored, Jesus tells us that our understanding of God should be centered solely upon Him. That is huge. We should never look past Jesus to find out where God is involved. Our concept of our Father should never be outside of the expression Jesus gave.

Let me ask you this: how many people did Jesus look at and say, "I'm not going to heal you. This sickness is for My glory. My Father is going to use this sickness for a greater good. I'm going to allow you to die and go on to heaven, because after all, that's ultimate healing"? Did Jesus ever say, "My Father has a date set for your death. You can only go when it's your time, no matter what you do or don't do. He's sovereign; He controls everything"? No. Jesus never said that to a person.

So we can't rely on our experience, our own reasoning, our denominational doctrines, or even isolated scriptures to give us an accurate perception of God. I know that's a bold statement, and it could sound somewhat blasphemous against Scripture, but think about it: the Old Testament presented God not inaccurately, but incompletely. If we want the complete expression of God, we must look at Jesus.

Another place these concepts are constructed is from what I call twisted scriptures. What is a twisted scripture? It's a verse taken out of context. When you hear a verse taken out of context, you can be conned by the text. Here is a verse that has been twisted for centuries. Psalm 115:3 says, "But our God is in heaven; He does whatever He pleases." That verse is not inaccurate, but it is incomplete. You have to take this verse, and others like it, in context with the whole passage.

If we don't take it in context, we will walk in what I call a convenient gospel. What is a convenient gospel? When someone asks why a tragic thing happened, why hundreds were killed in an earthquake, why a family member passed away, why they had a miscarriage, why they gave birth prematurely, why their child had a car wreck, or why a family member died even though they were a person of faith, it's convenient to say, "Well, His ways are far above ours. You never know what God is doing. I guess it was just their time to go. God needed another flower in His garden. He wanted another angel in His choir."

Don't you dare believe that God is growing a garden or building a choir and needs your loved one as a flower or a vocalist. That type of thinking comes from a demonically influenced and demonically charged view of God. Don't be offended, but you have to be religiously intoxicated to believe something like that. You must be branded with religion, not Scripture, not the Word, but religion, to believe such a doctrine.

Why is this such a widespread doctrine? There are two main reasons. First, it's convenient, as I've already pointed out. It's convenient to tell people, "You just never know what God is doing." Second, no one wants to take responsibility.

People will say things like, "Did you hear about Uncle Larry's liver? It's diseased." "Aunt Lucy's lungs are destroyed." "Papa Stewart's stomach just isn't well." "Brother Harry's heart is blocked." "Kyle's kidneys are failing." "Well, God must have a plan, because it couldn't happen if He didn't permit it." God is never the one weakening someone's liver, lungs, stomach, heart, or kidneys.

In fact, according to a nutritional website I was just reading, anger can weaken your liver, grief can weaken your lungs, worry can weaken your stomach, stress can affect and weaken your heart and your brain, and fear weakens your kidneys. This may not be true in every single case, but it is the norm. My point is this: God is not the one doing this to people. He is not your problem; He is your solution. The reason people accept this widespread doctrine of sovereignty is that we do not want to take responsibility.

"Well, Terry, I just believe everything happens for a reason." I do too. Somewhere, at some time, someone sowed a seed, and it happened for a reason. "Well, Terry, I'm getting a little offended at this message." Then it must be His will that you get offended. But wait, it's His will that I'm teaching you this. Now we're really mixed up. Do you see the calamity and chaos we create in our thinking when we don't understand how God is involved?

God is not in control. He is not the one determining who gets married, who gets divorced, who gets raped or murdered, who dies and when they die, or who wins the lottery and who doesn't. That's not God. If you think God is the one who controls when people die, then how do you explain abortions? Was it that child's time to die?

"But Terry, Scripture says God is in heaven and does what He pleases" (Psalm 115:3). If that's true in that context, then does it please God when a man opens fire on people worshiping at a church in Texas? Does it please God when babies are aborted, because after all, it's just their time to go and no one can go until it's their time? Did it please God when people of color were sold as slaves? Did it please God on 9/11 when the towers fell, killing thousands of people? Does it please God when girls are sold as sex slaves? Does it please God when a baby is born with an incomplete heart, lung, ear, nose, or eye? Do you really think God controlled this? Do you really believe He created that boy to shoot up that school in Florida? If you do, then your God is my devil.

Psalm 115:3 says God is in heaven and does what He pleases, but Psalm 115:16 says, "The highest heavens belong to the Lord, but the earth He has given to mankind."

Chapter 4: Human Agency and Responsibility

Earlier I played a few excerpts from some prominent speakers, and I want to say that I love and appreciate every one of them. I really do. I enjoy listening to some of them. I may not always agree, but I appreciate and honor them. I simply wanted to show how dominant this concept of sovereignty is. It's not accepted by a small group; it's accepted by the masses. And whether you realize it or not, it cripples believers.

If you think God is using the devil to teach you, to strengthen you, to build your faith, or for any reason at all, then you're deceived or you are a deceiver. You will not resist the devil if you think God is the one, as one of them put it, using the devil to deliver His mail to you, or using the devil to strengthen or perfect you. You will embrace, instead of resist, what the devil is doing to you.

God disarmed the devil. He defeated him. He stripped him down to nothing. The devil has never done the job of the Holy Spirit. If God wants to correct, train, teach, or guide you, He uses the Holy Spirit, and as you yield to the Holy Spirit, you get His results. How easy is that? It is so simple.

I want to play you two more speakers. I didn't give the names of those I played before, but I do want to give you these names: the two you're about to hear are Dan Mohler and Todd White. These brothers get it, and it's so easy. The reason it's such a challenge for some to grasp is that every day we hear that God controls all and that He is sovereign. I love how these brothers explain it. Listen to this, and I'll be back to show you from Scripture where sovereignty is involved in your life.

When we say God's not in control, it sounds blasphemous. What we're trying to say is that everything that happens is not the will of God. The power of life and death is in your tongue. If everything that's happening is the will of God, why would He put that kind of power in your tongue? People are destroyed for lack of knowledge. If everything is God's administrative choice, then why are we being destroyed for lack of knowledge? We would be destroyed by God's choice. Let's get the knowledge and stop the destruction.

People are reaping what they sowed; that's not God's administrative choice. Sometimes there are repercussions in life because we're not walking in faith or in truth, and then, in human wisdom, we turn around and put it on God, as if He sovereignly designed the thing, when we might be walking in ignorance or willfulness and it has nothing to do with God. God ordains life, not death. He's the

author and giver of life; He's not the thief. God receives your lost loved one when they pass away; He doesn't ordain their death. He told us to raise the dead, so why would He be taking people out? "I don't know why God took him." God didn't take anyone. He received them.

The bottom line is this: we are accountable. We've got a sword, we've got a shield, and we've got armor. Let's fight the good fight of faith. When you believe that God is sovereign in the sense that everything that happens is God's choice, it takes the fight out of a Christian. It disarms you, and that is exactly what hell would want: to disarm you.

Jesus said don't fear, and Jesus said don't worry, yet the first two reactions of the average Christian in crisis are to fear and worry and then cry out to God. It proves that we're walking in a very low level of understanding of authority, power, and God's choice. We've reduced the gospel to a method and a principle that we apply to try to get help, instead of a relationship we already have. If we're honest, we're driven by fear far more than we are driven by faith. We ought to stay humble and stop creating analogies to explain our problems and saying things to make our hurting hearts feel better at the cost of the truth that makes us free.

I was in intercessory prayer one day, and God said, "Dan, they've been calling Me the thief for generations." I could hear His heart, and I began to cry. I said, "God, You didn't steal anything. All You ever did was give Your Son, and we're accusing You of taking ours." There's a thief sneaking like a snake in the grass, laughing as he accuses God to men and men to God. Don't listen to the devil anymore. God is good, and He's the giver of life. Get out your sword, hold up your shield, and fight like you've never fought before.

Chapter 5: Dominion and Earthly Control

Many people are mad at God because they've been taught that God is in control. It's not even in the Bible. You won't find "God is in control" in the Bible. It's not Scripture, but we've made it scripture. I'm not saying God is not sovereign, because He is sovereign. But "God is sovereign" and "God is in control" are two totally different things. When you say God is in control, you encompass the idea that everything that happens is ordained by God. That's huge.

Bear with me, because some of you are very confused about what I'm saying right now. A lot of people have blamed God for things God didn't do. Satan has snuck in, bitten somebody, and gotten away like a snake in the grass, and God is taking the rap for it.

I was in the world and had no idea who God was. I thought that if there was a God, He was in control, and it was not good. That would mean that anybody who dies, anybody who gets hurt, anybody who dies an early death, God ordained it; that God said it was time for them to be taken out.

Then we have "God is in control" and "everything happens for a reason." What I'm learning, and what God is teaching me, is that when you hear that God is in control and that everything happens for a reason, your mind automatically links the two together: everything happens for a reason because God is in control. Then we wrap another scripture around both of them and say that all things work together for good for those who love God. It becomes a stronghold.

If you're taught that God is in control, and you lose a loved one to a horrible disease, and the preacher preaches that God is in control and He knows best, that sticks in you. Twenty years later you're angry with God, because if God did that to your mom, why wouldn't He have done the thousand other things you've put into the same category? Now you don't know who God is, and you think He is the thief who comes to steal, kill, and destroy.

There is a reason why everything happens, and the reasons fall into two categories. One category is stealing, killing, and destroying. The other category is life, and life more abundantly. If it's stealing, killing, and destroying, it is never God.

Genesis 1:26 says, "Then God said, 'Let Us make man in Our image, according to Our likeness; let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, over the birds of the air, and over the cattle, over all the earth.'" Did you hear that? We have control over all the earth. The psalmist said, "The earth is the Lord's, and the fullness thereof." Yes, I agree; that's the truth, and that's Scripture. He originated it and He created it, but He gave control, authority, and the right to rule and reign to mankind. Jesus said in Matthew 5:5 that the humble shall inherit the earth. The earth is under our control.

Here's the balance. I have yielded, and every day I continue to yield my will, my life, my heart, my mind, my actions, my thoughts, and my words to God. Why? Because I want His results. I want His wisdom. I want His will done on earth as it is in heaven. And since I control what goes on in the earth, I certainly want His wisdom on how to do it. Do you see where the balance is? We are redefining sovereignty.

Chapter 6: Sovereignty as Grace

So what happens in the earth is not up to God; it's up to people. God can only flow through one type of being, and that's a human being. Be honest: do you really believe God created that man in Texas to shoot up a church, killing 26 people? Do you really think God controlled that? "But Terry, He didn't stop it, so in that sense He allowed it to happen." You have to understand that He tried His best to stop it.

Think about it again. We must understand that He is limited in what He can and can't do in this earth. He works through people, and if you haven't noticed, people do not always do things perfectly. When you understand the story of the man who shot up that church in Texas, you'll discover there was a clerical error in the Air Force. When he was in the Air Force, they did not report to the FBI that this man was dangerous and had no business with a gun. Furthermore, his mother-in-law had been getting text messages warning her of how he wanted to treat her and that he wanted to hurt her. All of these warnings were ignored. I believe this was God warning, and the warnings were ignored. The mother-in-law said nothing. This man made an evil choice, and people suffered. How can I blame an absolutely good God for something we made a decision to allow to happen? You can't.

Thankfully, we understand the details of that story. We don't always understand the details of every event that happens; we don't always have that advantage. But rest assured, there are details, and there are reasons why things happen the way they happen, and God is never the problem. He is the source of continued help, not the cause of harm.

And that is sovereignty. Sovereignty is not the fact that it happened. Sovereignty is the healing after the fact. Please get hold of that. Sovereignty flows grace like a river into the areas of our weakness and our wrong decision-making. Thank You, Jesus. Sovereignty doesn't demand the act; sovereignty heals the results. That's sovereign.

When I make a mistake, when I rebel, whatever it is I do, and I begin to reap the consequences of my decisions, God's grace is still there. His wisdom is still there. He never backs off of my destiny. So when I yield my heart, my life, my words, and my thoughts to Him and say, "Father, I give You control. I'm tired of rebelling. I'm tired of running. Whatever it is, Father, I give You control," His grace is right there to lead me back to my destiny. That is sovereign.

I know some people are thinking, "Terry, if I believe this, then who can I blame?" We love to place blame on God. We love to blame the devil. We just don't want to blame ourselves; we don't want to take responsibility. I can't blame God for things that happen because of a wrong decision I make. Humanity has the right to rule the earth. We all make choices that have consequences, and do you know how many people suffer from wrong decisions made by other people? Millions.

Where did that start? In the garden. In Genesis 2:17, God told Adam not to eat of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. Was it God's will that they eat from the tree? No. He told them not to do it. "But I thought He was sovereign. I thought He controlled everything." If sovereignty is the controlling of all things, then a sovereign would never have to give an instruction. He gave them an instruction: don't do it.

What happened in Genesis? They ate of the tree. God told them not to do it, they made a decision, and thanks to Adam, billions have suffered. And who gets blamed? God. Who started the blame game? Adam: "It's this woman You gave me." Sovereignty did not demand the action. Where was sovereignty involved? He gave them another tree. Thank You, Jesus. Sovereignty does not tell you that you must do something wrong. Sovereignty says, "I'm so good that I'm going to give you another tree in spite of your bad decision." Sovereignty flows grace to the areas where humanity has made wrong decisions. We are redefining sovereignty.

Let's go a little further. In Genesis 13:10–11, Lot saw the land that became Sodom and Gomorrah. If God is sovereign the way Calvinistic thinking portrays Him to be, then it was His will that Lot choose Sodom. But we know this is not true because of Genesis chapter 1. The things that happen in this earth are up to us. Adam chose the tree. Lot chose the property. Bad choices, and people suffered. Where was God? Sovereignty didn't cause Lot to choose Sodom; sovereignty saved Lot from Sodom.

God is good, even after we mess up, after we make bad decisions, after we rebel. He is there to flow His grace. Take a moment right now and remember a time in your life when you made a bad decision. Remember the depths of darkness that decision put you in. Now remember how, in that darkest hour, the light of God's love pierced through, and He said, "Follow Me; I'll bring you out." That is sovereignty. Sovereignty didn't predestine you for trouble. Sovereignty had already provided a way out of the trouble, and when you yield your will to His way, you'll experience different results: heaven on earth. I trust this is magnifying the goodness of our Father to you, and I trust this is redefining what sovereignty is.

Sovereignty does not dictate that you make a bad decision. Sovereignty saves us from our bad choices as we yield to His deliverance. Are there still consequences? Yes. Do people still suffer? Yes. But if we will yield to His grace, repent, turn, and make a good decision to submit to God, then He can bring deliverance and restoration as people submit to that restoration.

Look at Jonah. He rebelled and made a bad decision, but God had a fish called grace. Jonah yielded to that grace, and God restored him. We are redefining sovereignty.

In Genesis 16:1–3, God had told Abraham and Sarah that they would have a son. Years passed, and Sarah grew impatient. She told Abraham, in effect, "Honey, I've got a servant girl here; go in to her." And Abraham said, "If that's what you really want, I just want to make you happy." Was it God's will that Abraham sleep with Hagar? No, it was not. Sovereignty did not demand it. Abraham had control over his part of the earth, and he made a bad human decision. It was his choice. Where was sovereignty involved? God still gave them Isaac. He is so good. Ishmael was man's decision; Isaac was God's sovereignty.

Bad decisions can last for generations. Thanks to Abraham and Sarah's bad decision, Isaac suffered Ishmael's criticism, and in many ways the conflict continues. Much of what we see happening in the Middle East is not ultimately about ISIS or Palestine; it's about Ishmael still being angry at Isaac. Why? Because someone made a bad decision.

This message should answer so many questions. It should show you that God is good. It should also show you that although we're under grace, there are still consequences to bad decisions. This is where a lot of my radical grace friends, including myself, need to be educated. If you know my ministry, you know I am an over-the-top, radical, hyper-grace preacher. My faith tells me I cannot get out of His grip. I'm secure in Christ Jesus. Why? Because it's not about my performance; it's about His.

But I can still make bad decisions, fail, and mess up. I can drive a hundred miles an hour in a 45-mile-per-hour zone, and that action may not put me in hell, but it could send me on to heaven a lot quicker than I need to go. Why? Because I made a decision. Furthermore, I'm leaving a legacy for the generations that follow.

Some people who have gotten hold of true grace have become passive. I know of people who do some horrible things and back it up with, "Well, God still loves me. I'm still going to heaven." Yes, you are; I agree. But how many of your kids and grandkids are your decisions impacting? We say, "It doesn't matter what I do; I'm still going to heaven. I'm secure in God's grace." I agree that you're secure in the grace of God, but you are still capable of making a bad decision that affects other people on this earth. Why? Because you have control.

Learn from Abraham. Did he sin? Yes. Did he mess up? Yes. Did he make wrong decisions? Yes. Did Abraham still go to heaven? Yes. That's God's sovereignty; that's His grace. But did generations suffer because of a bad decision? Absolutely. Sometimes our choices last for generations. How many people are fighting giants and demons in their own lives because of a choice made by a previous generation?

In 1 Samuel 17, David fought Goliath. If you haven't seen it, I encourage you to go to my YouTube channel, Facebook page, or website and watch the video segment "David and Goliath with a Twist." It's powerful. Let me play it for you now, because I want you to hear how our decisions affect generations to come. It's so important that we sow the right seeds and make the right choices, and thank God that even when we mess up and make a mistake, His grace still flows in our lives. That is sovereignty. I trust this message has been a blessing to you. We're going to end with this segment, titled "David and Goliath with a Twist."

Chapter 7: Breaking Generational Cycles

In 1 Samuel 17, David defeats Goliath. We celebrate that great victory. We've heard songs and sermons about it. But I want to take you on a different twist: who caused this fight? Have you ever thought about that? Who was responsible for bringing David and Goliath to battle?

You have to go to the Book of Ruth. There were two women named Ruth and Orpah, the daughters-in-law of Naomi. All three of these women's husbands died. When that happened, Naomi told them, "I'm leaving Moab, and I'm going back to the nation that has a covenant with God." Orpah said, "I'm going to stay here in Moab." Jewish tradition records that Orpah stayed in Moab and chose to live there. It was her choice; keep that in mind. She found a new husband. In those days there were still giants, and according to that tradition, Orpah became the wife of one of those giants and bore him four sons. One of those sons was named Goliath.

Ruth followed Naomi to the nation that had a covenant with God. She married Boaz, and they had a child named Obed. Obed had a child named Jesse, and Jesse had a child named David, the great-grandson of Ruth. David is now fighting the choice of Orpah. She made a decision, and now David is fighting the decision of a previous generation: Goliath.

Have you ever felt like you were fighting a battle because of a decision made by someone else? How many people are fighting giants and demons in their own lives because of a choice made by a previous generation? Seeds are powerful. Words and actions set the course of nature. If not for you, then for someone else; someone else will eat the fruit of the seeds you sow. So choose life.

David fought and conquered three things: the lion, the bear, and the giant. There are three things in your life you must conquer as well: the lion, the bear, and the giant.

The enemy prowls like a roaring lion, seeking whom he may devour. That is the enemy of your mind. You have to conquer your thoughts. God does not do this for you; you have to do it. How do you conquer thoughts? I wrote a book for you on that: Shut Up.

The pattern of a bear is very interesting: it only threatens when it feels threatened. A bear may charge at you just to see if it can intimidate you. Don't run. Stand your ground. Everything in your flesh may be screaming "Run," but you have to learn to stand. Maybe you have threatening issues in your life: a negative report from a doctor, or circumstances that aren't favorable. If you've got hell charging at you, why is it happening? Because you have become a threat. Like the bear, the enemy of your life feels threatened. How do you overcome? Stand your ground. Don't run. Don't give in. Don't quit. Don't get into fear. Do not be intimidated, even if things in life are charging at

you, by anything that defies the covenant you have with God through Christ Jesus.

Finally, you have to conquer the decisions of a previous generation. Was your father an alcoholic? Was your great-grandfather suicidal? Did your mom choose to live in the land with two giants, depression and fear? If so, I come into agreement with you that every decision made by a previous generation that has birthed a voice which defies your covenant with God, and which is trying to make you feel unworthy, weak, unfit, sick, diseased, or worthless, in the name of Jesus, come down. Fall under the mighty Word of God. Take up the sword of the Word of God right now and cut off any uncircumcised voice brought about by decisions made in a previous generation.

I call you blessed. I call you righteous, victorious, prosperous, glorious, healed, free, and living in victory. I empower you now: go forth, rule and reign as a king in this life, and go forth and enjoy the reward the Father has given you.